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Through the Lens of Fire: Photography and Resistance

Nehru Madan



On May 25, 2020, a white police officer knelt on the neck of George Floyd as he begged for air, repeatedly saying he could not breathe. Floyd was later pronounced dead. A bystander caught the moment on video, and it instantly went viral, spreading like wildfire across the entire country. This was the latest in a series of African American citizens dying unlawfully at the hands of police officers. As a result, protests and demonstrations in support of the

Black Lives Matter movement erupted in all fifty states, demanding institutional change in law enforcement. Statistics showed that Black Americans were three times as likely to be killed by police as their white counterparts, fueling public outrage (Altman). The COVID lockdown and President Trump's simultaneous rhetoric toward the Black Lives Matter movement intensified public anger, and several peaceful protests turned violent. Riots

and looting followed, as some believed that only disruption would make the urgency unmistakable. Things became particularly violent in Minneapolis, where Floyd's death occurred. Amid burning buildings and bullets flying, photographer Julio Cortez captured a photo of these riots that became a viral sensation across news and social media platforms almost instantly (Crary). Through his snapshot of a moment in Minneapolis, Cortez captured the essence of an entire country in turmoil.

The background of the photo is mostly dark, with a liquor store engulfed in flames taking up the majority of the frame. The store is breaking down, with fire raging both inside and outside, and its ceiling and storefront are already partially torn off. The frontmost wall of the store is marred with graffiti; the writings "Officers accountable" and "#BLM" are legible, both markers of the Black Lives Matter movement. The ground in front of the store is littered with debris and largely empty, suggesting that bystanders have fled. The flames stretch upward toward telephone lines, suggesting destruction beyond the frame. The burning telephone lines symbolize the movement's ability to transcend physical space—igniting conversation, movement, and change across an interconnected nation.

The bright orange flames dominate the frame, heightening the emotional gravity of the scene and evoking the anger and instability of the moment. The figure in the center of the frame remains in the shadows, creating a visual contrast with the bright background and immediately grabbing the viewer's attention. The protester is a silhouette whose features remain hidden, conveying anonymity and emphasizing the universality of the moment. The person could be of any race,

gender, or social class, the specifics being irrelevant to the story being told in the image. At a time when the country is so politically divided, this figure reminds us that we are all in it together as Americans. By keeping the person in the image anonymous, Cortez is telling us not to focus on the differences that divide us but to stay united during times of resistance.

The American flag the protester holds up is significant because it is upside down. Historically, an upside-down flag has been used in times of distress or political unrest. Upside-down flags have been flown during the Civil Rights Movement, anti-Vietnam protests, and after the 9/11 terrorist attacks. More recently, the upside-down flag has been used as a form of right-wing political protest. It has been seen at pro-life rallies and was flown around Trump's conviction in 2024 (Bowman). The U.S. flag code, first drafted in 1923, states that the American flag should be flown upside-down only "as a signal of dire distress in instances of extreme danger to life or property" (Bowman). While this is not a legally enforceable rule, it conveys the gravity of the flag being flown upside-down during the riots in Minnesota. The nearly translucent flag glows in the firelight, appearing vulnerable, as if it could be consumed next. This is reminiscent of the recent controversy about burning the American flag. While not technically illegal, flag burning is a highly polarizing form of protest that has garnered media attention in recent years. The flag in the photo, which looks to be on the cusp of burning, conveys the changing significance of what it means to be American.

The photograph's cultural impact extended far beyond the scene it captured. It appeared on several TV newscasts, headlined

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Twitter's What's Happening page, and eventually won a Pulitzer Prize in 2021 (Osborne). The photo emerged in the midst of a country ravaged by the pandemic, with African American communities disproportionately suffering (Altman). Yet frustration was widespread. Many Americans grappled with dissatisfaction toward the government, the loss of loved ones to the virus, and anxiety surrounding prolonged isolation. The nation reached a volatile tipping point at which something was bound to give. George Floyd's death and the subsequent wave of protests and violence ignited passionate discourse and anger across multiple perspectives. Through social media posts, articles, news broadcasts, art, literature, music, and photography, voices were amplified to an unprecedented magnitude, making it impossible to avoid the issue.

In the essay "Resistance," authors David Muggleton, Stuart Hall, and Ross Haenfler outline what it means to resist the dominant culture and defy societal norms. They categorize resistance in different forms: micro,

meso, or macro; overt or covert; and passive or active. The Black Lives Matter uprising in 2020 exemplifies macro, overt, and active resistance. It united individuals in opposition to patterns of violent policing (macro resistance); it gained widespread recognition by both the government and citizens who were initially uninvolved (overt resistance); and it intentionally disrupted the status quo (active resistance). Cortez's photograph captures all of this: The liquor store engulfed in flames, with graffiti lining its walls, demonstrates resistance in its boldest and most powerful form.

An immigrant himself, Cortez belonged to his own subculture. When he was just ten years old, his family snuck across the Mexican border in search of a better life in America. In high school, journalism quickly became his passion, and he would cover high school sports for the *Los Angeles Daily News* (Osborne). One day, while exploring the Daily News building, Cortez stumbled upon Suzanne Plunket's AP photo capturing the 9/11 terrorist attacks. He no-



ticed a look of terror etched on the faces of men in business attire as they ran for their lives from the growing cloud of smoke consuming the background of the frame (Osborne). While this photo was not an act of cultural resistance, Cortez recognized photography's ability to document history with immediacy and force. After becoming a permanent resident of the United States in July 2003, Cortez committed the rest of his career to honing his photographic skills, eventually earning a job at the Associated Press (Osborne).

Cortez's immigrant background provides a unique perspective on the 2020 photo of the Minneapolis riots. Cortez's undocumented status generally overshadowed his racial origin. His immigrant background might have shaped how he interpreted and documented moments of political resistance.

Additionally, immigration is a widely politicized topic, and pro-immigration groups have organized acts of resistance, including various protests and demonstrations. Cortez's identification with this subculture allowed him to sympathize with the resistance of the Black Lives Matter movement, positioning him to document the event with a distinct perspective.

Photography is a powerful art form, capable of telling stories through blocking, lighting, depth, and visual imagery. It can capture both fictional and historical interactions that transcend time and place, leaving a lasting impact. Photography is also subject to the viewer's interpretation. There is no one correct way to understand an image, and viewers can choose to focus on specific elements of a frame to uncover a picture's meaning.

In times of cultural resistance, photography serves as a preserved memory of culture, shaping our understanding of modern society. The photograph is likely to remain a visual record of a pivotal historical moment, not as an example of artistic technique but as a gateway to understanding a pivotal moment in American history. It offers a glimpse into a divided nation and the social resistance movement that captivated many.

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